SOFTWARE COMPANY OPERATIONS MANUAL

Working Practices, Support Levels and Security Policies | 2026

1. Company Overview

Northstar Digital Services is a fictional software company that develops web applications, data platforms, and internal business systems for small and medium-sized organisations. Its teams include Software Engineering, Quality Assurance, Product Design, Customer Support, Information Security, and Human Resources. The company uses a hybrid working model with approved office and remote-working days.

2. Working Hours and Attendance

The standard working day is eight hours, excluding a one-hour meal break. Core collaboration hours are 10:00 a.m. to 4:00 p.m. Employees may arrange the remaining hours flexibly with their manager, provided project and customer commitments are met. Team members must update their work calendar when taking leave or working remotely. Repeated absence without notice is referred to Human Resources.

3. Leave Policy

Full-time employees receive eighteen days of paid annual leave and twelve days of sick leave per calendar year. Annual leave requests of one or two days should normally be submitted at least three working days in advance. Requests for three or more consecutive days should be submitted at least ten working days in advance. Sick leave lasting more than two consecutive working days may require a medical certificate. Leave approval depends on team coverage and is confirmed by the employee's manager in the HR portal.

4. Project Management

Each project must have a named project owner, an agreed scope, acceptance criteria, a delivery timeline, and a risk register. Work is organised into two-week sprints. Sprint planning takes place on the first working day of each sprint, and sprint reviews are held on the final working day. Developers must link code changes to a tracked issue. Changes affecting a committed release date must be recorded in the project tracker and communicated to the project owner.

5. Code Review and Release Process

Every production code change requires review by at least one other engineer. Changes involving authentication, payment processing, personal data, or access control require an additional review from a designated senior engineer or security reviewer. Automated tests must pass before a change is merged into the main branch. Production releases require a release note, a rollback plan, and approval from the release owner. Emergency fixes may use an expedited process, but the review and documentation must be completed as soon as practical after deployment.

6. Customer Support Service Levels

Customer support classifies incidents into four priorities. Priority 1 incidents involve a major service outage or confirmed widespread data exposure and must be acknowledged within fifteen minutes. Priority 2 incidents significantly affect a major feature and must be acknowledged within one working hour. Priority 3 incidents affect a limited function and must be acknowledged within one business day. Priority 4 requests are general questions or minor improvements and must be acknowledged within three business days. Acknowledgement means that a support agent has confirmed receipt; it does not mean the issue has been resolved.

7. Information Security

Employees must use multi-factor authentication for company accounts and store work credentials only in the approved password manager. Passwords and authentication codes must never be shared through chat or email. Suspected phishing, lost devices, unexpected authentication prompts, or accidental data disclosure must be reported to security@northstar.example immediately. Employees must not copy customer data to personal storage accounts or unapproved devices.

8. Data Handling and Backups

Customer information is classified as Public, Internal, Confidential, or Restricted. Restricted data includes authentication secrets, payment details, and sensitive personal information. Access to Confidential and Restricted data must be approved for a business purpose and reviewed periodically. Production databases are backed up every six hours. Backup restoration tests are conducted quarterly. The target recovery point for a production database is six hours, while the target recovery time for a priority service is four hours, subject to incident conditions.

9. Remote Work and Equipment

Employees working remotely must use the company-approved virtual private network when accessing internal systems from an untrusted network. Devices must have screen locks, disk encryption, and supported security updates enabled. Company laptops and accessories are assigned through the IT asset register. Equipment loss or damage must be reported to the IT Help Desk within one hour of discovery. Employees must return company equipment within five working days of their final working day unless Human Resources approves another arrangement.

10. Training and Performance Reviews

New employees complete security awareness, data handling, and workplace conduct training within their first ten working days. Technical teams must complete role-specific training assigned by their manager. Formal performance reviews take place twice each year, in April and October. Reviews consider delivery quality, collaboration, communication, professional development, and agreed role objectives. Employees may add written comments to their review before it is finalised.

Contact Directory

Team	Responsibility	Contact
Customer Support	Incident reports and customer requests	support@northstar.example
Information Security	Phishing and security incidents	security@northstar.example
IT Help Desk	Devices, accounts and access	helpdesk@northstar.example
Human Resources	Leave and employee records	hr@northstar.example
Release Management	Production release coordination	releases@northstar.example

Note: This is a fictional organisation and the details are created solely for software testing and demonstration.